

Recently and lately

Teaching guide

Choose a tense that fits the event, not just the adverb.

Understand the distinction

Recently means a short time ago or during the recent past. It can describe one finished event with the past simple: I recently bought a bike. It also occurs with the present perfect: I have recently changed jobs.

Lately usually describes recent states or repeated activity, often with the present perfect: I have been busy lately; I have been cycling lately. It is less usual for a single finished event. Neither word requires the present perfect continuous, and neither guarantees that an activity will continue.

Compare the patterns

ONE EVENT

I recently visited a friend.

Past simple fits a finished visit.

RECENT STATE

I have been tired lately.

Been + adjective describes a state.

REPEATED ACTIVITY

I have been walking more lately.

The continuous form highlights activity.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose for a single visit: I visited Rome ____ . (recently / lately)

- A. recent
- B. lately
- C. recently

2. Is I have been busy lately a present perfect continuous verb?

- A. No. It is present perfect be followed by an adjective.
- B. Yes. Every phrase with have been is continuous.
- C. No. It is the past perfect.

3. Does I have been running lately guarantee future running?

- A. No. It describes recent activity.
- B. Yes. Lately always includes tomorrow.
- C. Yes. It promises the person will keep running.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair naturally describes one recent event and a recent repeated activity?

- A. I recently joined a class. I have studying more lately.
- B. I lately joined a class. I have been studying more lately.
- C. I recently joined a class. I have been studying more lately.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. recently

Recently readily refers to a single past event.

A: Recent is an adjective; this sentence needs an adverb.

B: Recently is the usual choice with this single past-simple visit.

2. A. No. It is present perfect be followed by an adjective.

The continuous form needs an -ing main verb.

B: Continuous forms need an -ing main verb. Busy is an adjective.

C: Past perfect would use had; have been is present perfect here.

3. A. No. It describes recent activity.

Future continuation needs more context.

B: Lately refers to the recent past, not a guaranteed future.

C: A report of recent activity does not promise future activity.

4. C. I recently joined a class. I have been studying more lately.

Recently fits the single event; lately fits the recent pattern of studying.

A: The continuous form needs been: have been studying.

B: Recently is the usual choice for this single past-simple event.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-16.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which pair naturally describes one recent event and a recent repeated activity?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.